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The Strange Case of Qays Al Kareem

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In December 1997, Qays A.M. Abd Al Kareem, a young Jordanian, joined Delhi University as a research student to do his doctoral degree in astrophysics. Five years later, he was back in Jordan, deported from India ‘due to his undesirable activities’. He had become yet another victim—though he was lucky to be alive—of the mysterious attack and aftermath of 13 December 2001.

A few months after he enrolled at Delhi University, Qays got accommodation in the Jubilee Hall hostel, a postgraduate hostel for men in the university. He expected to stay there till the completion of his degree, which was likely to take nearly five years. However, as an Arab Muslim, he was to become the target of constant abuse and harassment by some other students resident in Jubilee Hall who were associated with fundamentalist Hindu groups. The harassment was relentless, and the students targeting him eventually succeeded in getting him expelled from Jubilee Hall. During this long period Qays continuously approached the hostel and the university authorities for protection and assistance, but to no avail. He then turned to democratic sections of the university community for help. The person who took him to them was S.A.R. Geelani.[1]

Qays had first met Geelani, lecturer in Arabic at Zakir Hussain College, Delhi, and a civil liberties activist, on the research floor of the Central Reference Library, and later kept in touch because Geelani could speak to him in Arabic and was concerned enough about his situation to help him do something about it. Geelani took him to the People’s Union for Civil Liberties (PUCL). The PUCL General Secretary, Gopa Joshi of Ramjas College, Delhi University, intervened to seek alternative accommodation for Qays, so that he could complete his thesis in peace. The university gave him accommodation in the Teachers’ Transit Hostel for three months, from October to December